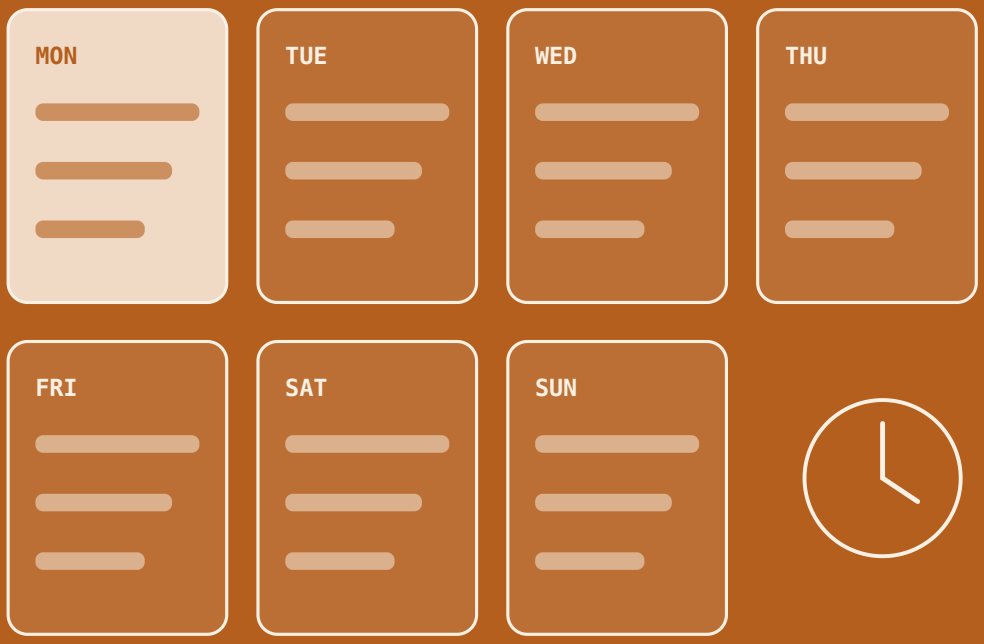


The Recipe Vault · Vol. 04

Simple & Quick

A 7-day food plan for busy weeks

SchoolAura

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How this plan works

This plan is for busy weeks: work, school runs, late evenings. It feeds **two adults for seven days** with balanced meals, and most dinners take **20 minutes or less** on the night. Double everything for a family of four.

The secret isn't fast recipes. It's **cooking once, eating twice**: a 90-minute prep session on Sunday makes the weekdays easy.

The rules

1. **Prep on Sunday.** Cook a grain, roast a tray of vegetables, make a soup, boil eggs and wash greens.
2. **Cook dinner three nights.** Leftovers become lunches. Two other nights take under 15 minutes.
3. **Keep breakfast boring.** Two or three good options on rotation saves daily decisions.
4. **Shop once.** One list, organised by aisle, for the whole week.
5. **Plan one flexible night.** Leftovers, eggs on toast or a night out. Real life happens.

What you need

- 2 large sheet pans, a large pot, a large frying pan
- 8–10 food storage containers with lids, plus a few jars for oats
- A sharp knife, a large cutting board and a timer

CHAPTER

The 7-day plan

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER
Mon	Overnight oats: berry	Tomato lentil soup + bread	One-pan lemon herb chicken & vegetables
Tue	Veggie scramble wrap	Chicken grain bowl (from Monday)	15-minute garlic shrimp noodles
Wed	Overnight oats: peanut butter banana	Tomato lentil soup	Black bean & corn tacos
Thu	Greek yogurt bowl	Chickpea & tuna salad	Sheet-pan sausage, peppers & potatoes
Fri	Veggie scramble wrap	Sausage & veg bowl (from Thursday)	Spinach & white bean pasta
Sat	Banana oat pancakes	Leftover pasta or eat out	Chicken fried rice
Sun	Eggs on toast with avocado	Soup or salad with what's left	Flexible night, then prep for next week

Snacks: fruit, a handful of nuts, yogurt, carrot sticks with hummus, boiled eggs, cheese and crackers.

Sunday prep: 90 minutes

Work in this order so the oven and stove are busy at the same time.

TIME	DO THIS
0:00	Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C). Put a pot of rice or quinoa on
0:05	Start the Tomato Lentil Soup (it simmers by itself)
0:15	Chop vegetables for Monday's tray and the week: peppers, onions, broccoli, carrots
0:30	Roast a tray of mixed vegetables for bowls and wraps (25 min)
0:35	Boil 6 eggs for 10 minutes, then cool in cold water
0:45	Make 2 jars of overnight oats
0:55	Wash and dry salad greens; store with a paper towel
1:05	Cool the rice quickly on a tray, then refrigerate
1:10	Portion the soup into containers. Freeze two portions if you like
1:20	Clean up and stick the plan on the fridge

Rice safety: spread cooked rice on a tray to cool quickly and refrigerate within 1 hour. Use it within 1–2 days, and reheat until steaming hot.

CHAPTER

Shopping list

For two adults for one week. Tick what you already have before you shop.

Produce

- 2 lemons, 2 limes
- 1 bag baby spinach, 1 head romaine
- 3 bell peppers, 2 onions, 1 red onion
- 1 head broccoli, 4 carrots, 1 zucchini
- 1 kg baby potatoes
- 1 head garlic, a thumb of ginger
- Green onions, fresh parsley or coriander
- 2 avocados, 6 bananas, 2 cups berries (fresh or frozen)
- 1 cucumber, cherry tomatoes

Protein and dairy

- 6 bone-in chicken thighs or 4 breasts
- 400 g raw shrimp (frozen is fine)
- 4 sausages (about 400 g)
- 2 dozen eggs
- 1 kg plain Greek yogurt
- Milk or unsweetened plant drink
- 150 g cheddar or feta, parmesan

Pantry

- 1 can each: black beans, chickpeas, white beans, corn
- 1 can tuna, 1 can (796 ml) crushed tomatoes
- 1 cup dried red lentils
- Rolled oats, chia seeds, peanut butter
- Rice or quinoa, 450 g pasta, 300 g egg or rice noodles
- Whole-wheat tortillas, bread
- Vegetable or chicken stock
- Soy sauce, olive oil, honey, Dijon mustard, salsa, hummus
- Cumin, smoked paprika, chilli flakes, dried oregano

CHAPTER

Breakfast

BREAKFAST · NO COOK

RECIPE 01

Overnight Oats, Three Ways

Five minutes the night before, zero minutes in the morning.

Serves 1 per jar | Prep 5 min | Chill overnight

INGREDIENTS

Base, per jar

- 45 g (½ cup) rolled oats
- 120 ml (½ cup) milk or plant drink
- 60 g (¼ cup) Greek yogurt
- 1 tbsp chia seeds
- 1 tsp honey or maple syrup (optional)

Choose a flavour

- **Berry:** ½ cup berries, a little lemon zest
- **Peanut butter banana:** 1 tbsp peanut butter, ½ sliced banana, pinch of cinnamon
- **Apple pie:** ½ grated apple, ½ tsp cinnamon, 1 tbsp chopped walnuts

METHOD

1. Stir the base ingredients together in a jar.
2. Add your flavour, stir, and close the lid.
3. Refrigerate overnight (at least 6 hours). Keeps for 3 days.
4. Eat cold, or microwave for 1–2 minutes with a splash more milk.

Five-Minute Veggie Scramble Wraps

Use leftover roasted vegetables from Sunday for an almost instant hot breakfast.

Serves 2 Cook 5 min

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 1 cup leftover roasted vegetables, chopped
- A handful of baby spinach
- 30 g cheddar or feta
- 2 whole-wheat tortillas
- Salt, pepper, hot sauce or salsa

METHOD

1. Warm the vegetables in a non-stick pan over medium heat for 1 minute. Add the spinach until it wilts.
2. Whisk the eggs with salt and pepper and pour into the pan. Stir gently until just set.
3. Sprinkle with cheese, divide between the tortillas, add salsa and roll up.

NOTES

- Wrap in foil to eat on the go.

Banana Oat Pancakes

Three main ingredients, naturally sweet, and ready in 15 minutes.

Serves 2 (about 8 small pancakes) | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 1 large ripe banana
- 2 large eggs
- 45 g (½ cup) rolled oats
- ½ tsp baking powder, pinch of cinnamon and salt
- Butter or oil for the pan
- Yogurt and berries, to serve

METHOD

1. Blend everything until smooth. Rest for 5 minutes to thicken.
2. Heat a lightly greased non-stick pan over medium-low heat.
3. Cook 2 tablespoons of batter per pancake for 2 minutes, until bubbles form, then flip and cook 1 minute more.
4. Serve with yogurt and berries.

Greek Yogurt Bowls

High protein and endlessly flexible.

Serves 1 Prep 2 min

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g (¾ cup) plain Greek yogurt
- ½ cup berries or chopped fruit
- 2 tbsp granola or toasted oats
- 1 tbsp nuts or seeds
- Drizzle of honey (optional)

METHOD

1. Spoon the yogurt into a bowl.
2. Top with fruit, granola and nuts, and drizzle with honey if you like.

CHAPTER

Lunch

LUNCH · MAKE AHEAD

RECIPE 05

Big-Batch Tomato Lentil Soup

Thick, warming and very cheap. Makes enough for four lunches; freezes well.

Serves 6 | Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 onion, chopped
- 2 carrots, chopped
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, pinch of chilli flakes
- 200 g (1 cup) dried red lentils, rinsed
- 1 can (796 ml) crushed tomatoes
- 1.25 L (5 cups) vegetable or chicken stock
- 2 handfuls spinach
- Juice of ½ lemon, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pot over medium heat. Cook the onion and carrots for 6–8 minutes until soft.
2. Add the garlic and spices and stir for 1 minute.
3. Add the lentils, tomatoes and stock. Bring to a boil, then simmer for 20–25 minutes, stirring now and then, until the lentils are soft.
4. Stir in the spinach and lemon juice. Season well. Blend partly for a creamier soup.
5. Cool, then portion into containers. Keeps 4 days in the fridge or 3 months in the freezer.

Chicken Grain Bowls

Leftovers become a fresh lunch. Pack in the morning in two minutes.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups cooked rice or quinoa (from Sunday)
- Leftover lemon herb chicken, sliced
- 1 cup roasted vegetables
- Cucumber, cherry tomatoes, spinach
- 2 tbsp hummus or yogurt

Quick dressing

- 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp Dijon, 1 tsp honey, salt

METHOD

1. Divide the grains between two containers.
2. Top with chicken, vegetables and salad.
3. Add a spoon of hummus. Pack the dressing separately.

Chickpea & Tuna Salad

Protein, fibre and crunch in ten minutes. Lasts two days in the fridge.

Serves 2 Prep 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can (540 ml) chickpeas, drained and rinsed
- 1 can tuna, drained
- ½ cucumber, diced
- 1 cup cherry tomatoes, halved
- ¼ red onion, finely chopped
- Handful of parsley, chopped
- 2 tbsp olive oil, juice of 1 lemon, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Toss everything together in a large bowl.
2. Taste and add more lemon, salt or pepper.
3. Eat as it is, over greens or stuffed into a wrap.

NOTES

- Vegetarian? Swap the tuna for feta and a chopped hard-boiled egg.

CHAPTER

Dinner

DINNER · ONE PAN

RECIPE 08

One-Pan Lemon Herb Chicken & Vegetables

Everything roasts together on one tray. Make extra for Tuesday's lunch bowls.

Serves 2 + leftovers | Prep 10 min | Cook 35–40 min

INGREDIENTS

- 6 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
- 500 g baby potatoes, halved
- 1 head broccoli, cut into florets
- 1 red onion, cut into wedges
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 lemon, zest and juice
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp dried oregano, 1 tsp smoked paprika, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C).
2. Toss the potatoes and onion with 1 tbsp oil and salt on a large sheet pan. Roast for 10 minutes.
3. Mix the remaining oil with lemon zest, juice, garlic, oregano, paprika, salt and pepper. Rub over the chicken.
4. Push the potatoes to the sides, add the chicken skin-side up and roast for 20 minutes.
5. Add the broccoli, toss with the pan juices, and roast for 8–10 minutes more, until the chicken reaches 74°C (165°F) and the skin is crisp.

15-Minute Garlic Shrimp Noodles

Faster than takeout. Have everything chopped before you start; it moves quickly.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 150 g egg or rice noodles
- 250 g raw shrimp, peeled
- 1 pepper, thinly sliced
- 2 cups spinach or bok choy
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp grated ginger
- 1 tbsp oil

Sauce

3 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp honey, 1 tsp sesame oil, 1 tbsp lime juice, pinch of chilli flakes

METHOD

1. Cook the noodles according to the packet. Drain and rinse briefly.
2. Mix the sauce ingredients in a cup.
3. Heat the oil in a large pan over high heat. Cook the shrimp for 2 minutes until pink; remove.
4. Add the pepper for 2 minutes, then the garlic and ginger for 30 seconds.
5. Add the noodles, greens, shrimp and sauce. Toss for 1–2 minutes until glossy.

Black Bean & Corn Tacos

Ready in 15 minutes from cans you already have.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can (540 ml) black beans, drained and rinsed
- 1 cup canned or frozen corn
- 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, salt
- 6 small tortillas
- 1 avocado, mashed with lime juice and salt
- Salsa, shredded lettuce, cheese or yogurt

METHOD

1. Warm the beans and corn in a pan with the spices and a splash of water for 5 minutes. Mash about a third of the beans.
2. Warm the tortillas in a dry pan or the microwave.
3. Fill with beans, avocado, salsa, lettuce and cheese.

Sheet-Pan Sausage, Peppers & Potatoes

Hands-off comfort food. Make enough for Friday's lunch.

Serves 2 + leftovers | Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min

INGREDIENTS

- 4 sausages (about 400 g)
- 500 g baby potatoes, halved
- 2 peppers, cut into strips
- 1 onion, cut into wedges
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1 tsp dried oregano, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C).
2. Toss the potatoes with half the oil and seasoning on a sheet pan. Roast for 10 minutes.
3. Add the peppers, onion, remaining oil and the sausages. Roast for 20–22 minutes, turning the sausages once, until cooked through (71°C / 160°F for pork, 74°C / 165°F for chicken sausages).

Spinach & White Bean Pasta

A pantry pasta with garlic, lemon and parmesan that tastes far better than its effort.

Serves 2 + 1 lunch | Prep 5 min | Cook 15 min

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g short pasta
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 4 garlic cloves, sliced
- Pinch of chilli flakes
- 1 can (540 ml) white beans, drained and rinsed
- 3 large handfuls spinach
- Zest and juice of 1 lemon
- 40 g parmesan, grated, plus extra to serve

METHOD

1. Cook the pasta in well-salted water. Save a mug of pasta water before draining.
2. Meanwhile, warm the oil and garlic in a large pan over medium heat until the garlic is lightly golden. Add the chilli.
3. Add the beans and cook for 3 minutes, mashing a few.
4. Add the drained pasta, spinach, lemon zest and juice, parmesan and a splash of pasta water. Toss until glossy.

Chicken Fried Rice

The best use for cold leftover rice. Use any vegetables you have.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 3 cups cold cooked rice (from Sunday, used within 1–2 days)
- 1–1½ cups cooked chicken, chopped
- 1 cup frozen peas and carrots, or chopped vegetables
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp oil

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan or wok over high heat. Scramble the eggs quickly and set aside.
2. Add the vegetables, garlic and green onion whites for 2 minutes.
3. Add the rice, breaking up clumps, and stir-fry for 4 minutes until hot and slightly crisp.
4. Add the chicken, eggs, soy sauce and sesame oil. Toss for 2 minutes until steaming hot. Top with green onions.

CHAPTER

Leftovers & budget

The leftover remix

YOU HAVE	TURN IT INTO
Roast chicken	Grain bowls, wraps, fried rice, soup
Roasted vegetables	Scramble wraps, pasta, blended into soup
Cooked rice	Fried rice (within 1–2 days)
Soup	Lunches, or a sauce for pasta
Half a can of beans	Tacos, salads, mashed on toast
Spinach about to wilt	Smoothies, soup, pasta, eggs
Overripe bananas	Pancakes, oats, freeze for smoothies

Ten ways to spend less

1. Shop with a list and stick to it.
2. Check the fridge and cupboards before you shop.
3. Buy frozen vegetables and fruit: cheaper, no waste, just as nutritious.
4. Buy rice, oats, lentils and pasta in bigger bags.
5. Use beans and lentils for some meals instead of meat.
6. Buy whole chickens or bone-in thighs; they cost less per kilo.
7. Choose store brands for staples.
8. Cook once, eat twice.
9. Freeze bread, leftovers and ripe fruit before they go off.
10. Plan one "use it up" meal every week.

CHAPTER

Your weekly planner

Photocopy or print this page each week.

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	PREP NOTE
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Shopping list